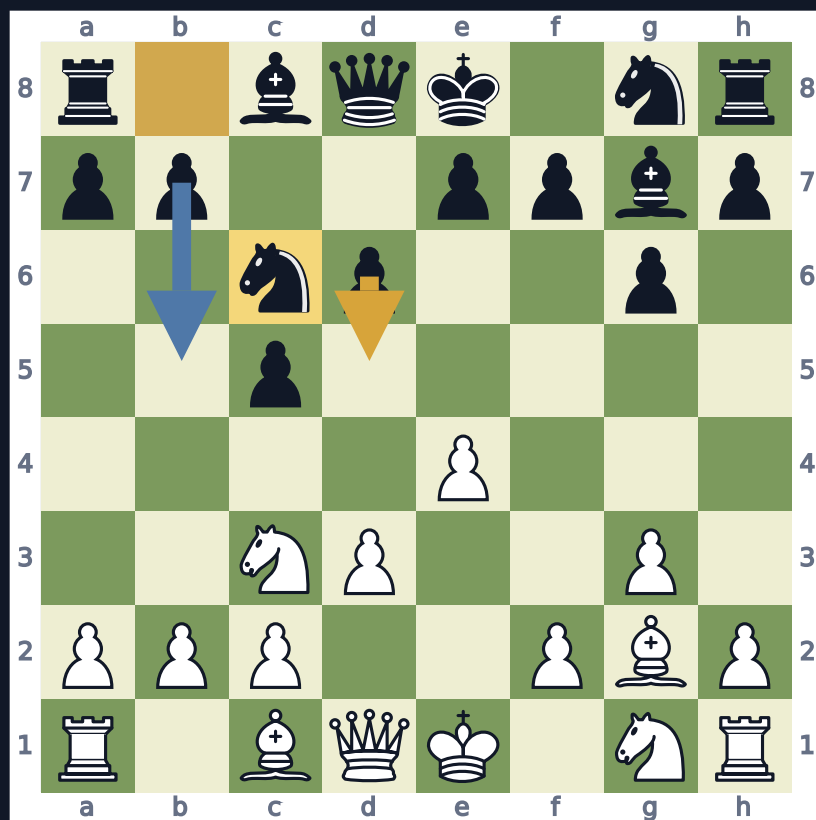


10

Closed Sicilian Systems

Slow centers, kingside expansion, and the ...d5 break that prevents a one-sided attack.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will meet Closed Sicilians with active central play rather than waiting behind a familiar setup.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 055 | PAGE 4

Decode: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian*Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.*

LESSON 056 | PAGE 8

Play: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian*Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.*

LESSON 057 | PAGE 12

Decode: Botvinnik pawn triangle*A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.*

LESSON 058 | PAGE 16

Play: Botvinnik pawn triangle*A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.*

LESSON 059 | PAGE 20

Decode: Early ...d5 equalizer*The best answer to a slow flank buildup is often a timely central question.*

LESSON 060 | PAGE 24

Play: Early ...d5 equalizer*The best answer to a slow flank buildup is often a timely central question.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will meet Closed Sicilians with active central play rather than waiting behind a familiar setup.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Without d4, the center stays closed and White can build f4-f5; Black receives time for central and queenside counterplay.

DECISION RULE

Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Prepare ...d5, use ...Nge7, and challenge the pawn chain before White's kingside space becomes an attack.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White plays f4, Nf3, O-O, and g4 or f5, often using the closed center as a shield.

MEMORY RULE | Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Without d4, the center stays closed and White can build f4-f5; Black receives time for central and queenside counterplay.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Prepare ...d5, use ...Nge7, and challenge the pawn chain before White's kingside space becomes an attack.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White plays f4, Nf3, O-O, and g4 or f5, often using the closed center as a shield.

FAILURE MODE

Copying White's slow wing play and allowing an uncontested kingside bind.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 d6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 Nc6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7



- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Without d4, the center stays closed and White can build f4-f5; Black receives time for central and queenside counterplay.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe? White's resistance is: White plays f4, Nf3, O-O, and g4 or f5, often using the closed center as a shield. The line fails as a template when: Copying White's slow wing play and allowing an uncontested kingside bind.

STORE THIS | Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Without d4, the center stays closed and White can build f4-f5; Black receives time for central and queenside counterplay. 2. Prepare ...d5, use ...Nge7, and challenge the pawn chain before White's kingside space becomes an attack. 3. White plays f4, Nf3, O-O, and g4 or f5, often using the closed center as a shield. 4. Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe? 5. Copying White's slow wing play and allowing an uncontested kingside bind.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 Nc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Without d4, the center stays closed and White can build f4-f5; Black receives time for central and queenside counterplay.

DECISION RULE

Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe?

SIDE TO MOVE

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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Without d4, the center stays closed and White can build f4-f5; Black receives time for central and queenside counterplay.

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Copying White's slow wing play and allowing an uncontested kingside bind.

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Ask: Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 d6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 Nc6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7



- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- f4: White claims kingside space and announces e5 or f5 attacking ideas.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nge7: Black reroutes a knight to e7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Without d4, the center stays closed and White can build f4-f5; Black receives time for central and queenside counterplay.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe? White's resistance is: White plays f4, Nf3, O-O, and g4 or f5, often using the closed center as a shield. The line fails as a template when: Copying White's slow wing play and allowing an uncontested kingside bind.

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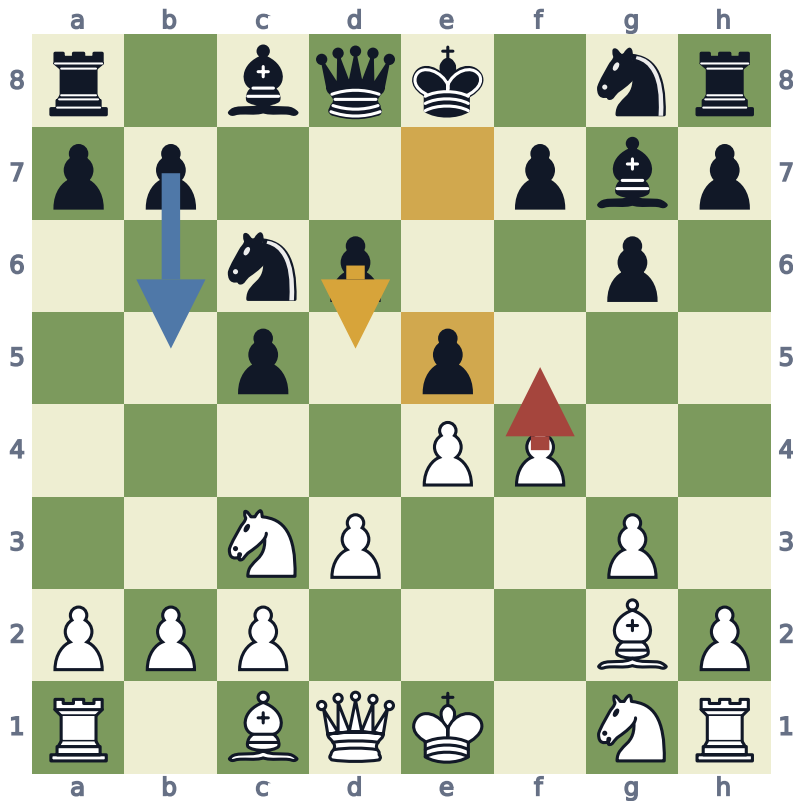
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. d3 Nc6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Botvinnik pawn triangle



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White's e4-d3-f4 triangle clamps central squares and prepares f5, but d4 and the dark squares can become targets.

DECISION RULE

Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use ...exf4 only for a reason, maneuver toward d4, and seek queenside space or a timed ...f5.

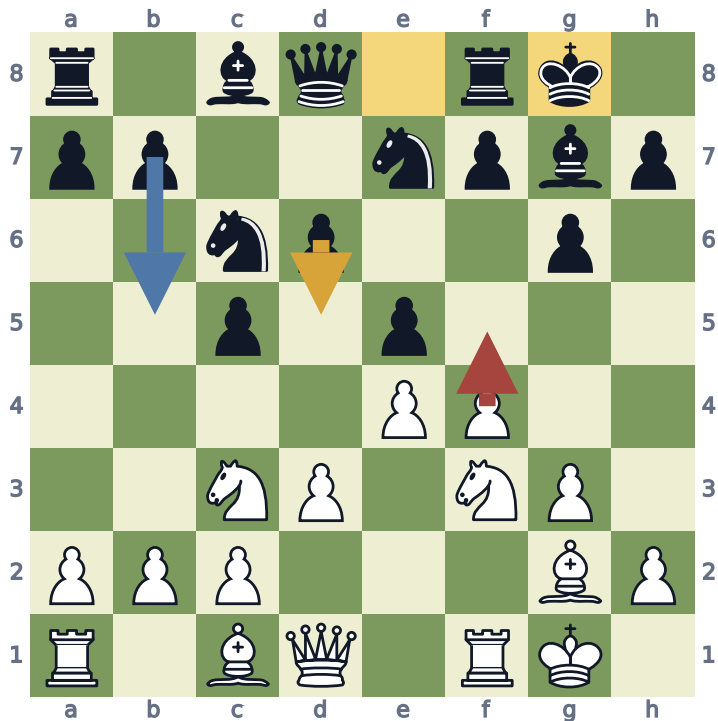
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White maintains the clamp, reroutes pieces behind it, and chooses f5 when Black cannot counter in the center.

MEMORY RULE | A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White's e4-d3-f4 triangle clamps central squares and prepares f5, but d4 and the dark squares can become targets.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use ...exf4 only for a reason, maneuver toward d4, and seek queenside space or a timed ...f5.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White maintains the clamp, reroutes pieces behind it, and chooses f5 when Black cannot counter in the center.

FAILURE MODE

Closing the position further without a route for the minor pieces.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

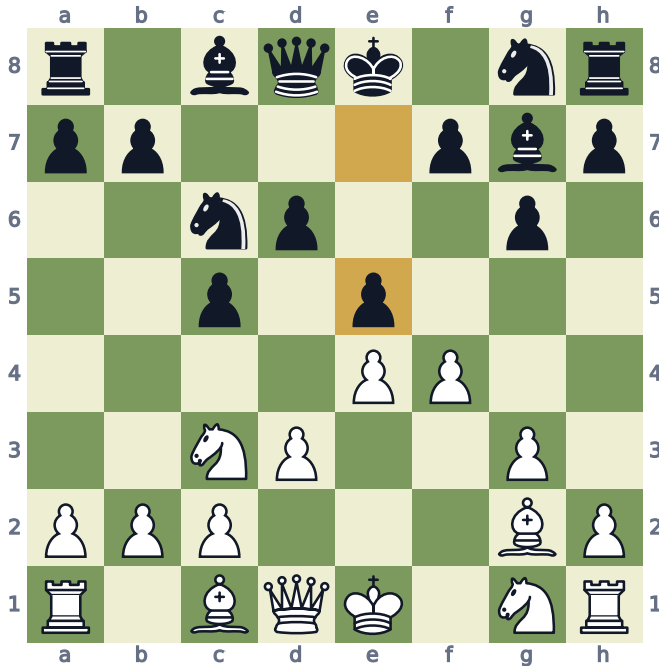
RULE | A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 d6 6. f4 e5 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O



- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- f4: White claims kingside space and announces e5 or f5 attacking ideas.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's e4-d3-f4 triangle clamps central squares and prepares f5, but d4 and the dark squares can become targets.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it? White's resistance is: White maintains the clamp, reroutes pieces behind it, and chooses f5 when Black cannot counter in the center. The line fails as a template when: Closing the position further without a route for the minor pieces.

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Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

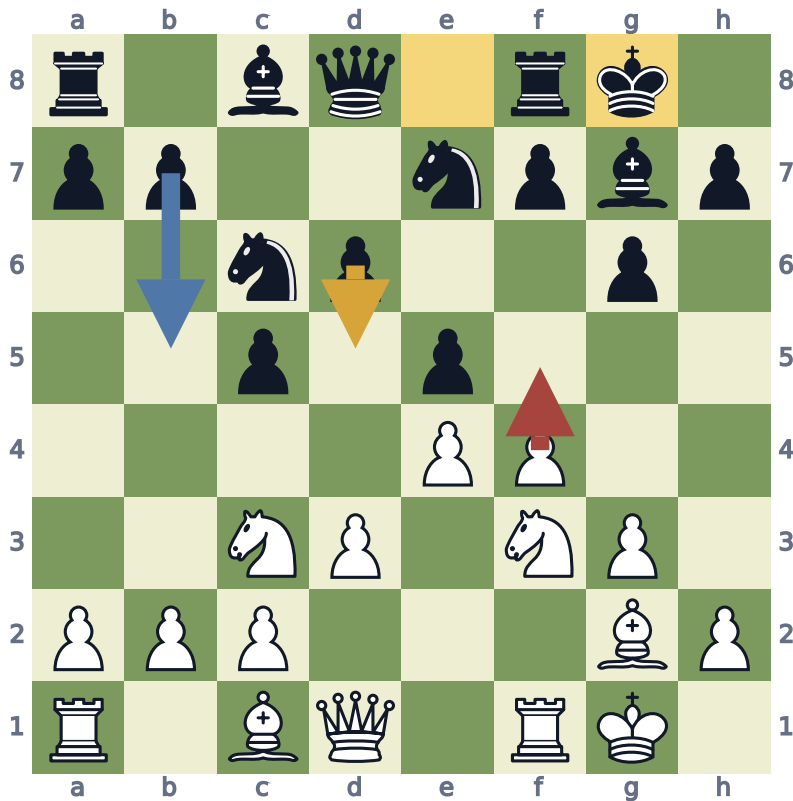
1. White's e4-d3-f4 triangle clamps central squares and prepares f5, but d4 and the dark squares can become targets. 2. Use ...exf4 only for a reason, maneuver toward d4, and seek queenside space or a timed ...f5. 3. White maintains the clamp, reroutes pieces behind it, and chooses f5 when Black cannot counter in the center. 4. Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it? 5. Closing the position further without a route for the minor pieces.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 d6 6. f4 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Botvinnik pawn triangle



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White's e4-d3-f4 triangle clamps central squares and prepares f5, but d4 and the dark squares can become targets.

DECISION RULE

Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use ...exf4 only for a reason, maneuver toward d4, and seek queenside space or a timed ...f5.

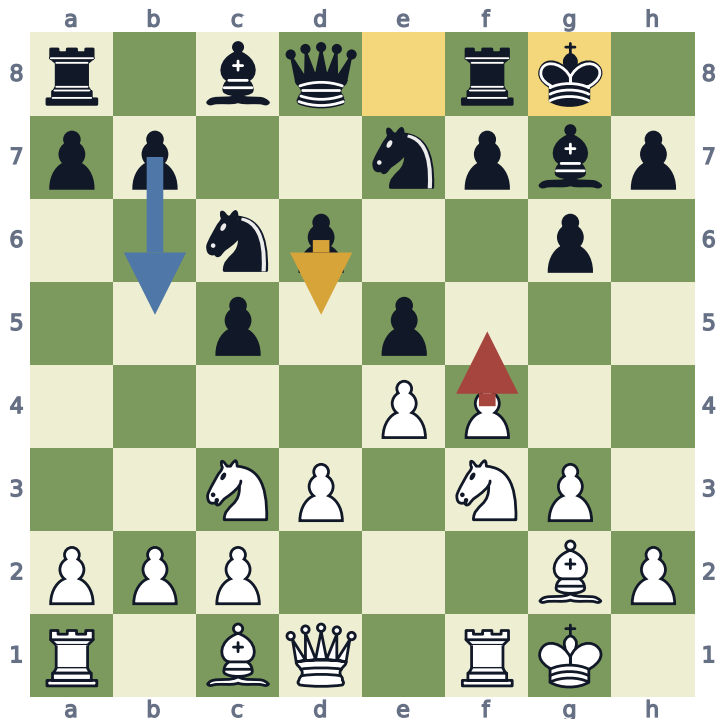
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White maintains the clamp, reroutes pieces behind it, and chooses f5 when Black cannot counter in the center.

MEMORY RULE | A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

Use ...exf4 only for a reason, maneuver toward d4, and seek queenside space or a timed ...f5.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White maintains the clamp, reroutes pieces behind it, and chooses f5 when Black cannot counter in the center.

FAILURE MODE

Closing the position further without a route for the minor pieces.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

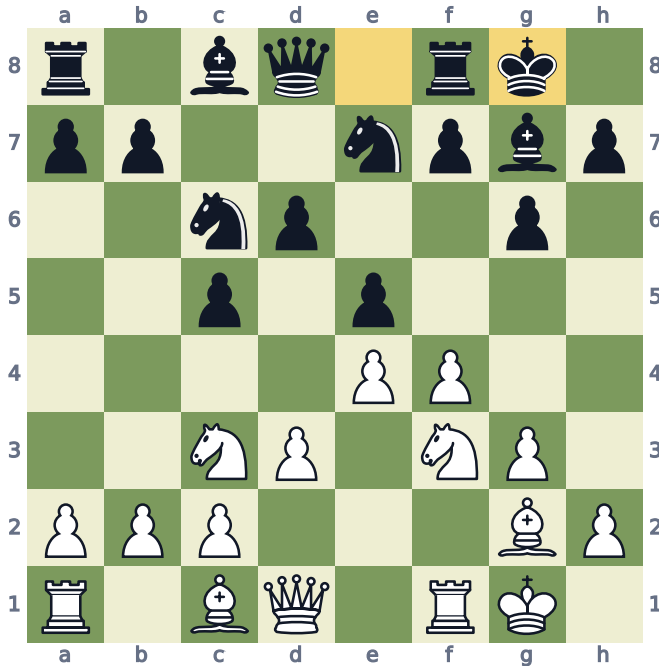
RULE | A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 d6 6. f4 e5 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O



- f4: White claims kingside space and announces e5 or f5 attacking ideas.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nge7: Black reroutes a knight to e7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's e4-d3-f4 triangle clamps central squares and prepares f5, but d4 and the dark squares can become targets.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it? White's resistance is: White maintains the clamp, reroutes pieces behind it, and chooses f5 when Black cannot counter in the center. The line fails as a template when: Closing the position further without a route for the minor pieces.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

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ANSWER KEY

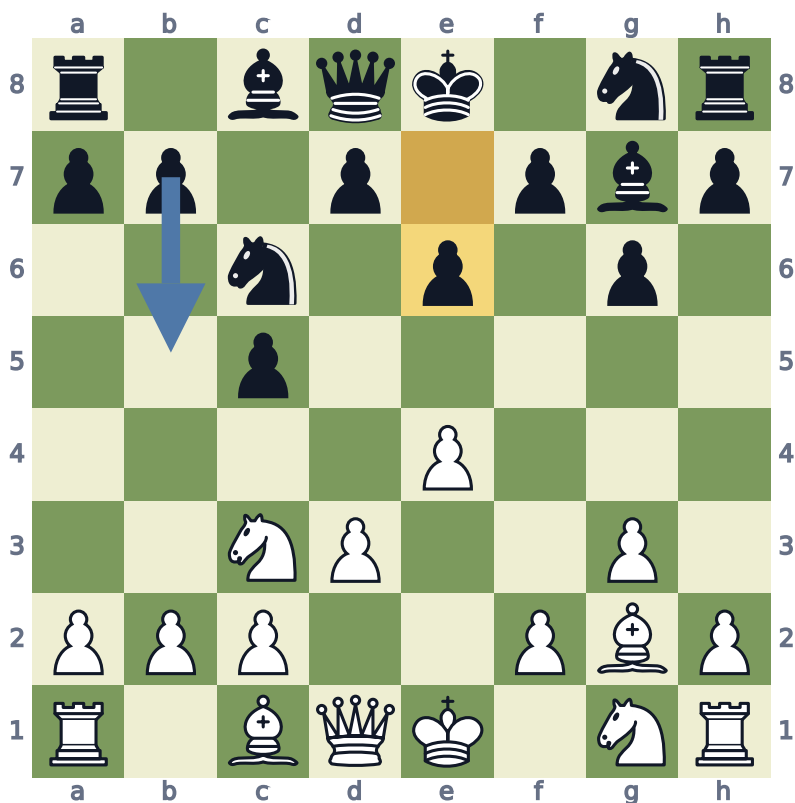
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. f4 e5 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Early ...d5 equalizer



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...d5 challenges White before the kingside buildup is complete and often turns the game into an open central struggle.

DECISION RULE

After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Support the break, accept exchanges that free the pieces, and avoid leaving d5 as a loose target.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may e5, exd5, or keep tension, choosing the structure that best preserves kingside chances.

MEMORY RULE | The best answer to a slow flank buildup is often a timely central question.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...d5 challenges White before the kingside buildup is complete and often turns the game into an open central struggle.

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Support the break, accept exchanges that free the pieces, and avoid leaving d5 as a loose target.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White may e5, exd5, or keep tension, choosing the structure that best preserves kingside chances.

FAILURE MODE

Playing the correct break with insufficient support and losing the d5 pawn tactically.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

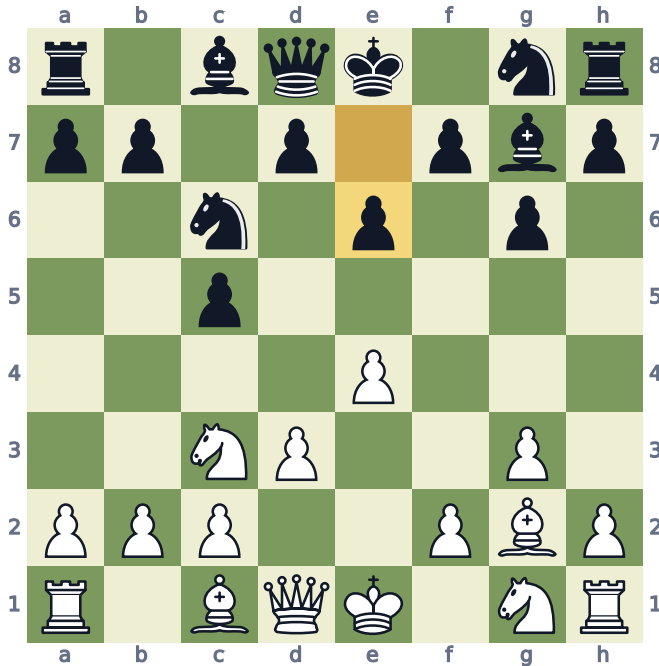
RULE | The best answer to a slow flank buildup is often a timely central question.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 e6 6. f4 Nge7 7. Nf3 d5



- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
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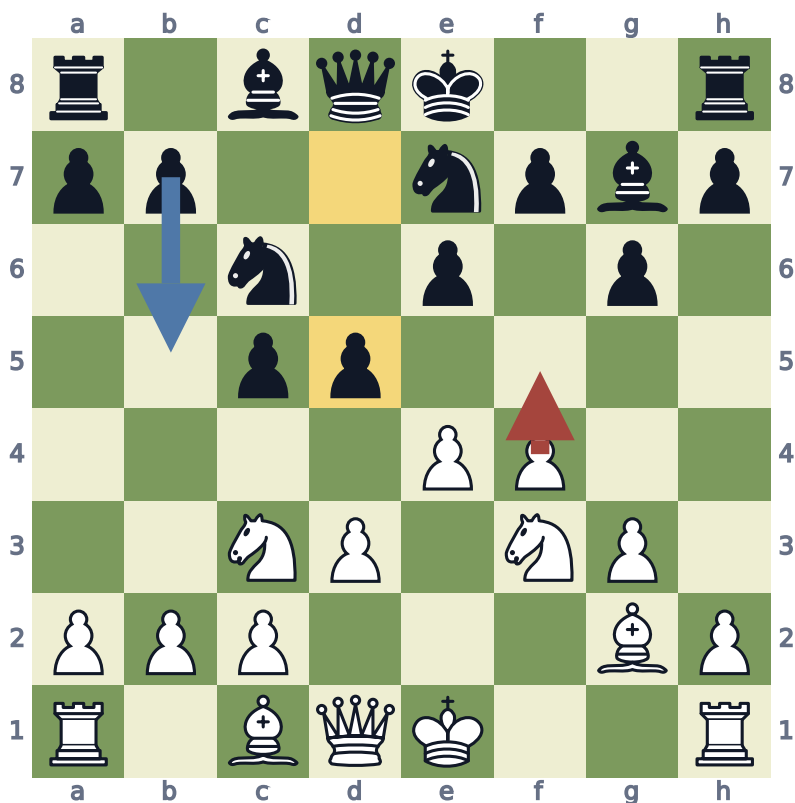
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 e6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Early ...d5 equalizer



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...d5 challenges White before the kingside buildup is complete and often turns the game into an open central struggle.

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After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares?

SIDE TO MOVE

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BLACK'S JOB

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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CUE

...d5 challenges White before the kingside buildup is complete and often turns the game into an open central struggle.

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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FAILURE MODE

Playing the correct break with insufficient support and losing the d5 pawn tactically.

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Ask: After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

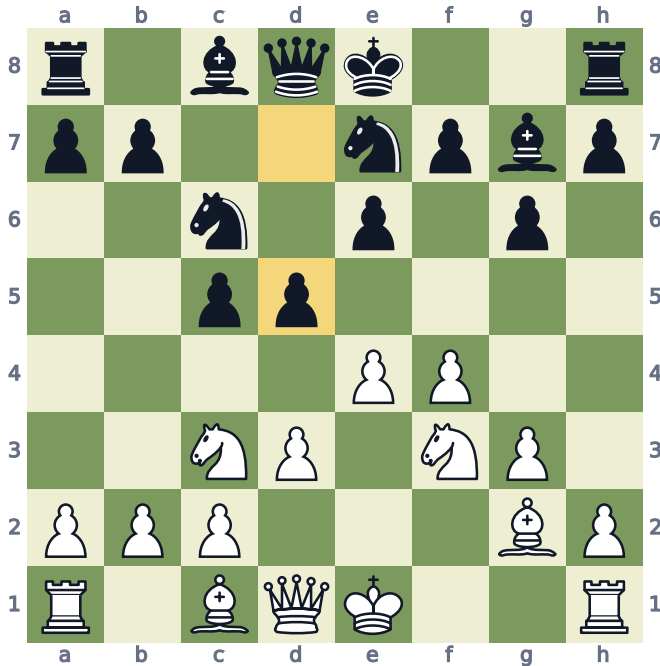
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 e6 6. f4 Nge7 7. Nf3 d5



- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- f4: White claims kingside space and announces e5 or f5 attacking ideas.
- Nge7: Black reroutes a knight to e7; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- d5: Black plays the freeing central break; its tactical soundness matters more than its thematic reputation.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...d5 challenges White before the kingside buildup is complete and often turns the game into an open central struggle.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares? White's resistance is: White may e5, exd5, or keep tension, choosing the structure that best preserves kingside chances. The line fails as a template when: Playing the correct break with insufficient support and losing the d5 pawn tactically.

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5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. ...d5 challenges White before the kingside buildup is complete and often turns the game into an open central struggle. 2. Support the break, accept exchanges that free the pieces, and avoid leaving d5 as a loose target. 3. White may e5, exd5, or keep tension, choosing the structure that best preserves kingside chances. 4. After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares? 5. Playing the correct break with insufficient support and losing the d5 pawn tactically.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. d3 e6 6. f4 Nge7 7. Nf3 d5

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 055 Decode: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian

Prompt: Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe?

Recall: Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.

LESSON 056 Play: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian

Prompt: Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe?

Recall: Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.

LESSON 057 Decode: Botvinnik pawn triangle

Prompt: Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it?

Recall: A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.

LESSON 058 Play: Botvinnik pawn triangle

Prompt: Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it?

Recall: A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.

LESSON 059 Decode: Early ...d5 equalizer

Prompt: After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares?

Recall: The best answer to a slow flank buildup is often a timely central question.

LESSON 060 Play: Early ...d5 equalizer

Prompt: After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares?

Recall: The best answer to a slow flank buildup is often a timely central question.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Fianchetto Closed Sicilian

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 d6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 Nc6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7

Decision: Can Black play ...d5 now, or which preparatory move makes it safe?

Memory: Against a closed wing attack, open the center before the storm arrives.

CARD 2

Botvinnik pawn triangle

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 d6 6. f4 e5 7. Nf3 Nge7 8. O-O O-O

Decision: Which square behind White's pawn chain can become an outpost, and which exchange opens it?

Memory: A space clamp has squares behind it; attack the base, not the tip.

CARD 3

Early ...d5 equalizer

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 e6 6. f4 Nge7 7. Nf3 d5

Decision: After each white response to ...d5, which side benefits from the opened files and changed knight squares?

Memory: The best answer to a slow flank buildup is often a timely central question.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
055 Decode: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
056 Play: Fianchetto Closed Sicilian	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
057 Decode: Botvinnik pawn triangle	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
058 Play: Botvinnik pawn triangle	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
059 Decode: Early ...d5 equalizer	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
060 Play: Early ...d5 equalizer	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.